FREE GUIDE FOR SERIOUS BRASS PLAYERS

The 1% Audition Guide

The system that took me from 19 lost auditions to winning orchestra positions.

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I lost 19 auditions, many in the final round, while practising more hours than anyone around me. What changed was not my talent or my hours. It was **how** I prepared. This is the preparation I now use with my students, from conservatory entrance exams to principal positions.

> "In every audition I won, I was never the best player in the room. I was the best prepared."

01 Start months before, not weeks

Most players open the music a few weeks before the audition. That is already too late. Start **three to five months out**, so you peak on the day instead of cramming.

- **Know the list before it is published.** Watch Musical Chairs and Last Row Music, and message players in the section. Many lists barely change from one audition to the next.
- **No list yet? Prepare the core.** On trombone that is the David Concertino (1st and 2nd movements) plus Tuba Mirum, Bolero, Also sprach Zarathustra, William Tell, Ride of the Valkyries and the Hungarian March. Every instrument has its own "core five".
- **Be ready on short notice.** Orchestras sometimes call on a Saturday for a Tuesday. If your core is always ready, that call is an opportunity, not a panic.

02 One audition round a day: your non-negotiable

Practising excerpts is not the same as performing them. Every single day, play a full round **as if it were the audition**. It takes 30 to 40 minutes, even on a heavy orchestra week.

The rule: never stop. If a note cracks, you keep going. On the day, the pianist will not stop for you, and one stop breaks your focus for the rest of the round.

MY DAILY ROUND

15 min	Short warm-up, the same one you will use on the day
Solo	Concerto movements in audition mode, no stopping
5 min	Break, like waiting between rounds
Excerpts	6–8 in a row, in the order of the list

03 Practise more without the instrument

Practice does not make perfect. **Practice makes permanent.** Repeat a mistake enough and your brain learns the mistake. Some of my best work happens with no trombone in my hands, and it keeps both your lips and your head fresh.

- **Sing every excerpt with the subdivision** ("ta-ka-ta-ka"). If you cannot sing it in time, you will not play it in time.
- **Mental practice:** a famous Harvard experiment had one pianist practise on a piano and another only in their head for three months. At the recital they sounded similar.
- Piano, clapping rhythms, listening to recordings and to **your own recorded lessons** all count as practice.

04 Record yourself, a lot

While you play, too much happens at once to hear yourself honestly. Record several takes a day and listen back like a jury. A phone is enough, but **set the levels first**: play your loudest and softest passages so nothing distorts. For video rounds, sound quality matters more than people think: a Berlin Philharmonic mentor told me most of the 90 videos for his festival were unusable because of the audio.

05 Perform, don't just practise

Everything works in the practice room, then on stage we block. That is not because you are bad. It is because **you never practised under pressure**. Play mock auditions for colleagues, friends, your teacher, a phone camera that you treat as a jury. Do it again and again until performing feels normal. That is how your worst day starts beating other players' best day. I won my last audition with a fever, barely able to breathe.

06 Visualise the whole audition, every day

This changed the game for me. **20 minutes a day**, eyes closed, live the full audition: arriving, your warm-up, walking on stage, the tuning note, every breath and every phrase of the solo and excerpts, waiting between rounds, and the moment they announce **you** as the winner.

- Start 130 days out and you will have won that audition 130 times before you walk in. You start to believe it, and you start acting like the winner.
- Add a few minutes of daily meditation for a calm, "blue sky" head, and protect your focus. A 15-minute solo is hard to play when your attention span has been trained by 10-second reels.

07 Win it before the first note

Most players do not lose an excerpt on the notes. They lose it **before they play**, because the tempo and the character are not clear yet. Before every excerpt: hear the orchestra or the piano in your head, feel the tempo, then **breathe in tempo** and play. Train this every day until it is automatic, because a bad habit here is very hard to remove later.

08 On the day: arrive fresh

- **Play less in the last 2–3 days.** One of my students took two days off before his auditions on my advice. He won two principal positions that week.
- **Keep the warm-up short**, around 15 minutes. You need lips for the final round, not just the first.
- **Save bullets for the end.** In my Helsinki final they asked for the whole Frank Martin Ballade. I had rehearsed that scenario in my head. My opponent had not.
- **Risk with the music, not with control.** Bold ideas, safe habits. And whatever happens, keep going.

09 Your countdown

3–5 months	Get the list or prepare the core. Start the daily round and 20 minutes of visualisation.
2 months	Record daily takes. First mock auditions for other people.
1 month	Play full rounds in the order of the list, including the scenario of a surprise final round.
Last week	Fewer hours, more off-horn practice. Sing and visualise every excerpt.
The day	Short warm-up. Tempo in your head, breathe in tempo, never stop.

FREE MASTERCLASS

This is only the start of the method

In my free masterclass I show the full 1% system: how to practise better in fewer hours, how to play on stage the way you play in the practice room, and how to build an embouchure made for you.

alegriamusic.net/watch →

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